



SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN

HIGHFLIERS' HAVEN: NAL
headquarters in Bangalore

NATIONAL AEROSPACE LABORATORIES, BANGALORE

THE AIRBORNE CLAN

SPREADING ITS WINGS

NAL has ventured into societal sciences—solar coating for water heaters, wind turbines for wind energy harvesting and saline water ponds for solar energy harvesting.

PLANE FACTS

The Indian Air Force is in talks with NAL to procure 15 Saras planes, and possibly more later.

Dubbed a “well-decked bride with nowhere to go” throughout the 1970s, in 2004, the National Aerospace Laboratories (NAL) finally earned its stripes, developing Saras, India’s first multi-purpose civilian aircraft. With an annual R&D budget of Rs 120 crore, NAL spearheaded India’s space programme and the light combat aircraft project of 1983. Srinivas Bhogle, who headed NAL’s information management division until recently, wrote that there were two factors which contributed to the setting up of NAL. First, the emergence of the troika of P. Nilakantan, V. M. Ghatage and Satish Dhawan, which worked together on dozens of national aeronautical committees, and virtually wrote the country’s aeronautical R&D agenda for the future. And, also, the preparation for an outstanding 50-page report (January 1956) by Nilakantan, its first director, titled ‘Organisation of Aeronautical Research and Development in India’. Formed in 1959, NAL

moved to Bangalore from Delhi a year later. It was then that the National Aeronautical Laboratories was renamed National Aerospace Laboratories to reflect its major involvement in the Indian space programme, its multidisciplinary activities and global positioning.

NAL’s most fascinating and ambitious feature, the supersonic wind tunnels through which one can study the flow of air around solid objects was set up in what is now known as the Wind Tunnel Road in Bangalore. The project cost NAL Rs 2.2 crore and was completed in 1964. In recent years, a shadow seems to have been cast on the organisation as it faces a serious talent crunch, thanks to the private companies that have lured NAL’s brilliant scientists by the dozen. Meanwhile, NAL has also been collaborating with other countries on some special projects. Says A.R. Upadhyaya, director, NAL, “All I can say is, NAL has many suitors now.”

by Swagata Sen

SHAILESH RAVAL

NATIONAL DAIRY DEVELOPMENT BOARD, ANAND

THE SECOND CHAPTER

Wowed after seeing the cooperative dairy structure that Verghese Kurien, the architect of the success of Amul Dairy in Anand, had created, Lal Bahadur Shastri asked him to build a similar model at the national level. Kurien agreed on the condition that the organisation would be based in Anand. In 1965, Shastri set up the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB) under Kurien’s chairmanship. The NDDB has created a structure that ensures 1.30 crore Indian farmers earn Rs 10,000 crore annually on their milk produce. Says its Chairman Amrita Patel, “In the next 15 years, we plan to triple the number of milk producers and double the numbers of villages.” Seems the Milky Way is the only way to go for the NDDB.

by Uday Mahurkar

SUCCESS UNLIMITED:
Amrita Patel at NDDB

“The NDDB has brought about this revolution by involving small farmers which is its biggest achievement.”

AMRITA PATIL, CHAIRMAN, NDDB